

HAZARD 5 — HYPOTHERMIA IN ALL SEASONS

Hypothermia — the dangerous lowering of core body temperature — is not a winter-only event in New England. It is an all-season risk at elevation and in wet conditions, and it kills people in July on the Presidential Range who arrived at the trailhead that morning in sunshine.

The conditions that produce hypothermia are wet, wind, and cold — and in New England's mountains, you can have all three simultaneously in any month. A temperature of 50°F, combined with sustained rain and a 30-mph wind, produces an effective wind chill well below freezing. Wet cotton against the skin accelerates heat loss to a rate that the body cannot compensate for without external intervention.

What you need to know:

- Early-stage hypothermia produces shivering, confusion, slurred speech, and poor coordination. The person affected is often the last to recognize it.
- A hypothermic person needs to be warmed from the outside: shelter from wind and wet, dry insulating layers, warm (not hot) beverages if conscious, and body heat if necessary.
- Prevention is the entire game. Carry a rain layer. Carry insulation even on warm days if you are going above treeline. Change out of wet base layers at the summit before the descent, when you stop generating heat. Eat and drink consistently — cold and hungry is a short road to hypothermic.
- Full hypothermia recognition and treatment protocol is in Chapter 7.

